

Tufte inspired Typst template (in Quarto)

The Tufte-Memo Usage guide and background

AUTHOR ONE

An Organization
email@email.com

NOAH GULA

github.com/nogula

CHRISTOPHER T. KENNY

github.com/christopherkenny

April 24, 2026

This Quarto template adopts many aspects of the design and typography of Edward Tufte’s books and extends [nogula](#)’s Typst template. The document itself demonstrates the functionality and usage of the template, including setup, sidenotes, figure display, citations, and more.

Introduction

Edward Tufte is an American statistician, professor, and pioneer in the field of data visualization, known for his work on the visual presentation of data and information. He is the author of influential books such as “The Visual Display of Quantitative Information” E. R. Tufte [1] and is renowned for his principles on clarity, precision, and efficiency in data graphics. His books have inspired a unique design and typography, created by Howard Gralla.

This template adopts many of the conventions used by Gralla and Tufte and allows the interested author to obtain a similar appearance to style of Tufte’s publications. However, the design adapts the book-format to work as an article (i.e., not having multiple parts and chapters and so forth, but instead something more akin to a memo or academic journal article).

This document is a skeuomorph¹ of the template; it intends to demonstrate the template’s functionality across various frontmatter styles, citations, figures, and importantly, sidenotes.

[1] E. R. Tufte, *Visual Display of Quantitative Information*, Second. Cheshire, Connecticut: Graphics Press, 2001.

¹ This document is not only a skeuomorph, but also tests the template itself.

Using this template

This template will function primarily as a normal Quarto template and requires no special configuration to use the basic features. However, to get full use of all Tufte-style features, you may find some additional options useful. This template uses Quarto 1.9's native article layout support via the Marginalia package, which provides standard margin layout features.

The next sections demonstrate how to use wide blocks, side notes, and figures in the margin.

This template requires Quarto 1.9 or later. Add the following to your document metadata to enable Tufte-style margin features:

```
reference-location: margin
citation-location: margin
```

With these options set, footnotes become numbered sidenotes and citations appear alongside their references in the right margin.

Wide Blocks

You may have noticed that this text spans the entire width of the page whereas the preceding two pages were compressed to a four-inch-wide column in the typical manner of Tufte books. The template allows you to break the narrow column format when desired by using Quarto's native `.column-page-right` class, which extends content to span both the body and the right margin. The simplest way to use it is with a div:

```
::: {.column-page-right}
your content
:::
```

The `.column-page-right` class spans body and margin combined, which can be useful when a full page does not contain any sidenotes and the text would otherwise look awkward being unnecessarily compressed into a narrow column.

Sidenotes

In Tufte books, sidenotes² are a distinctive feature: they are used for a variety of purposes, but mainly to provide non-critical but related information. In a basic sense, they are simply footnotes but put on the side, appearing closer to the text being referenced.

With `reference-location: margin` set in the document metadata, standard Quarto footnotes are automatically rendered as numbered sidenotes in the right margin. Create a sidenote using standard footnote syntax:

```
Text with a sidenote^[The sidenote content
appears in the margin].
```

Here is a sentence with an example sidenote³.

To place content in the margin without a footnote number, use the `.aside` class:

```
[Content for the margin without a number.]
{.aside}
```

The `.column-margin` class works the same way for block-level content:

```
::: {.column-margin}
Content placed in the margin.
:::
```

The sidenote can contain any content, including figures, tables, and other formatted elements.

Citations in the Margin

Citations follow the standard [Quarto citation syntax](#). With `citation-location: margin` set in the document metadata, cited sources are automatically displayed in the right margin alongside the text that references them.

² This is a sidenote; perhaps you have already noticed them in this document.

³ This is an example sidenote

This sidenote has no number.

Figures

Figures can be displayed in three different ways. A standard figure, which sits within the body text can be placed as normal, without any special configuration. This is demonstrated with Figure 1, below. These figures only occupy the four-inch-wide space making up the width of the document.

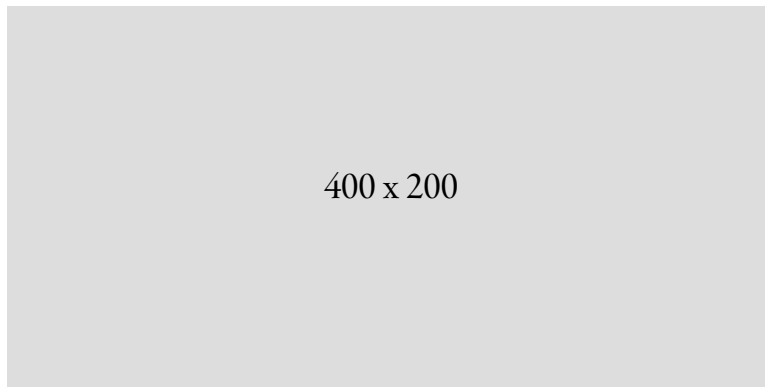


Figure 1. This is just a plain figure.

Second, a `.column-page-right` div can be used to display a larger (or, at least wider) figure in the text, which spans the full body and margin width. This is demonstrated with Figure 2.



Figure 2. The widest figure you've ever seen!

Note that this figure also demonstrates the ability to place raw Typst blocks within figures. You can mix and match as you see fit, but I strongly recommend using the basic figure formatting from Quarto, otherwise you may need to manually control figure kinds and their respective counters. In general, if you use Quarto syntax where possible and only resort to raw Typst at the last moment (like above using `#rect` only after setting up the figure), things should work.

Third, you can also display figures in the margin using the `.column-margin` class. Figure 3 demonstrates this.

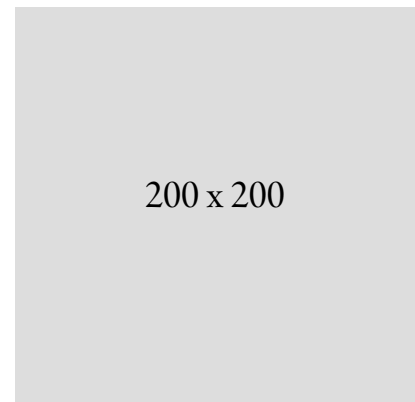


Figure 3. This is a little figure in the margin.

Other Formatting

This template supports headings up to and including the third level. Levels below this are supported, but will use standard Quarto styling.

Text is displayed with a modest lightness (`luma(30)`) to reduce the harshness of the contrast between the type and the paper; links are displayed underline like `<www.example.com>`.

To start a bibliography on a new page, it is recommended to use the `{{< pagebreak >}}` `shortcode` which is included in Quarto automatically.

Epilogue

nogula's original thanks

Thank you to Edward Tufte for inspiring this template, and to other Typst contributors.

christopherkenny's thanks

Thank you to nogula for building the Typst template from which this Quarto template is built, and to the Quarto team for Quarto 1.9's native Marginalia support that powers the sidenotes and column layout in this template.

References

- [1] E. R. Tufte, *Visual Display of Quantitative Information*, Second. Cheshire, Connecticut: Graphics Press, 2001.